

Session 14: Burden of Leadership

Key Takeaways

- Two conversations with Jethro frame Israel's deliverance story ([Exod. 4](#) and [18](#)).
- Jethro represents the first of many nations who will acknowledge Yahweh's greatness because of his victory over Pharaoh.
- It seems noble of Moses to shoulder the burden of all the people, but it's unwise.

Exodus 18 in the Literary Design of Exodus

[Exodus 4:18-31](#) and [Exodus 18](#) frame Israel's deliverance story.

- Moses speaks with Jethro ([Exod. 4:18a](#); [18:5-12](#)).
- Jethro offers a blessing of peace ([Exod. 4:18b](#); [18:7](#)).
- Zipporah travels with Moses' sons ([Exod. 4:20](#); [18:6](#)).
- The noun *ḥōtēn*, which can mean father-in-law or other male in-law, appears in both passages ([Exod. 4:18](#); [18:1](#), [7-8](#), [24](#), [27](#)); Zipporah also uses the related noun *ḥātan* ([Exod. 4:25-26](#)), which refers more broadly to a relative by marriage.
- Aaron greets Moses with a kiss at the mountain of God ([Exod. 4:27](#)); Moses greets Jethro with a kiss near the mountain of God ([Exod. 18:5-7](#)).
- Both passages include Aaron and the "elders of Israel" ([Exod. 4:29](#); [18:12](#)).

Note the vague location in [Exodus 18:5](#). This reserves "Sinai" for later so that this incident can participate in the wilderness framing of the Sinai narratives.

Jethro's Testimony

Exodus 18:10-11 NIV

¹⁰ Praise be to the LORD, who rescued you from the hand of the Egyptians and of Pharaoh, and who rescued the people from the hand of the Egyptians. ¹¹ Now I know that the LORD is greater than all other gods, for he did this to those who had treated Israel arrogantly.

Jethro's testimony affirms the literary structure of the book: rescue of Moses + rescue of Israel = the nations know YHWH is greater than all gods.

Exodus 18 in the Literary Design of the Torah

Exodus 18 and Numbers 10-11 frame the Sinai narratives.

- Moses receives advice from a Midianite family member (Exod. 18:17-23; Num. 10:29-31).
- Moses struggles under the burden of leadership (Exod. 18:13-16; Num. 11:10-17).
- Moses appoints elders to share the burden (Exod. 18:24-26; Num. 11:24-25).

Moses' complaint in Numbers 11 echoes Jethro's words from Exodus 18.

Exodus 18:18b Instructor's Translation

For this thing is too heavy for you; you are unable to do it alone.

כי־כבד ממך הדבר
לא־תוכל עֲשֹׂהוּ לְבַדְךָ:

Numbers 11:14 Instructor's Translation

I myself am unable alone to carry all this people, for it is too heavy for me.

לֹא־אוּכַל אֲנִי לְבַדִּי
לְשַׂאת אֶת־כָּל־הָעָם הַזֶּה
כִּי כבד ממני

Reflection Question

Reflect on Jethro's role in bearing witness to Israel's deliverance and Yahweh's greatness. How do you see this connecting to other biblical themes?



Module 3: A Covenant at Mount Sinai

SESSIONS 15-22

Examine God's commandments in their historical and literary context to better understand their meaning and see how they teach us about God's character and nature.